

Raptor Center's Wings Clipped — Lack Of Money Delays Building

By DIANNE WHITACRE
Staff Writer

The Carolina Raptor Center has come up \$30,000 short in its goal of raising money to build an environmental education center.

Construction of the center will be delayed until early summer while the nonprofit organization tries to raise the rest of the money, said Pat Marcum, executive director.

The Raptor Center, which treats and releases injured birds of prey from the East Coast, had been given a pledge of \$100,000 if it began construction in 1990, but a fund drive fell \$30,000 short, Marcum said.

Fred and Edna Moretti will still honor their \$100,000 pledge, Marcum said. "They realize it's taking a bit longer than we thought," she said.

The education building will be named for Edna Moretti, a volunteer at the Raptor Center.

Among the pledges received were those from Hoechst Celanese Corp., \$15,000; Lance Inc., \$10,000; the Kathleen Price and Joseph Bryan Family Foundation, \$10,000; Piedmont Natural Gas, \$5,000; the raptor center board of directors, \$5,000; and Blumenthal Foundation, \$1,000.

Marcum said the cost of the \$290,000 center was reduced \$70,000 by delaying construction of the environmental center's auditorium, but the fund drive still came up short.

The Raptor Center is now headquartered in two trailers in Latta Plantation Park — one its raptor hospital and the other an office. The environmental education center will be built on Sample Road, next



Marcum

to the raptor center's trails where hawks, eagles, owls and vultures are on display in outdoor cages. Those birds survived injuries from gunshots, poisonings and collisions with cars, but can no longer fly.

Marcum said the center will start construction within six weeks on a 50-car gravel parking lot that will serve the new education building and the current trails. Construction of the building itself should start in early summer and be completed in the fall.

The environmental education center will have an exhibit hall, auditorium, offices, gift shop, an aviary for the American kestrel, or small falcon, and another for the Eastern screech owl. An indoor exhibit will give visitors an underground look at burrowing owls.

An outdoor viewing area will have a small pond, feeders and plants chosen to attract birds and other wildlife. Within the next 10 years, the raptor center wants to move its hospital into a building complete with surgical and X-ray equipment for the 300 to 400 injured birds of prey it treats each year. When that move is made, the center will become more involved in research and breeding endangered species.

Architect Herbert Lawton has prepared free preliminary drawings for the center. Lawton designed the Jimmy Carter Library in Atlanta.

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To make a donation, send a check to the Carolina Raptor Center, P.O. Box 16443, Charlotte, N.C. 28297. The center is in Latta Plantation Park, on Sample Road off Beatties Ford Road. Winter hours are noon to 5 p.m. weekends.